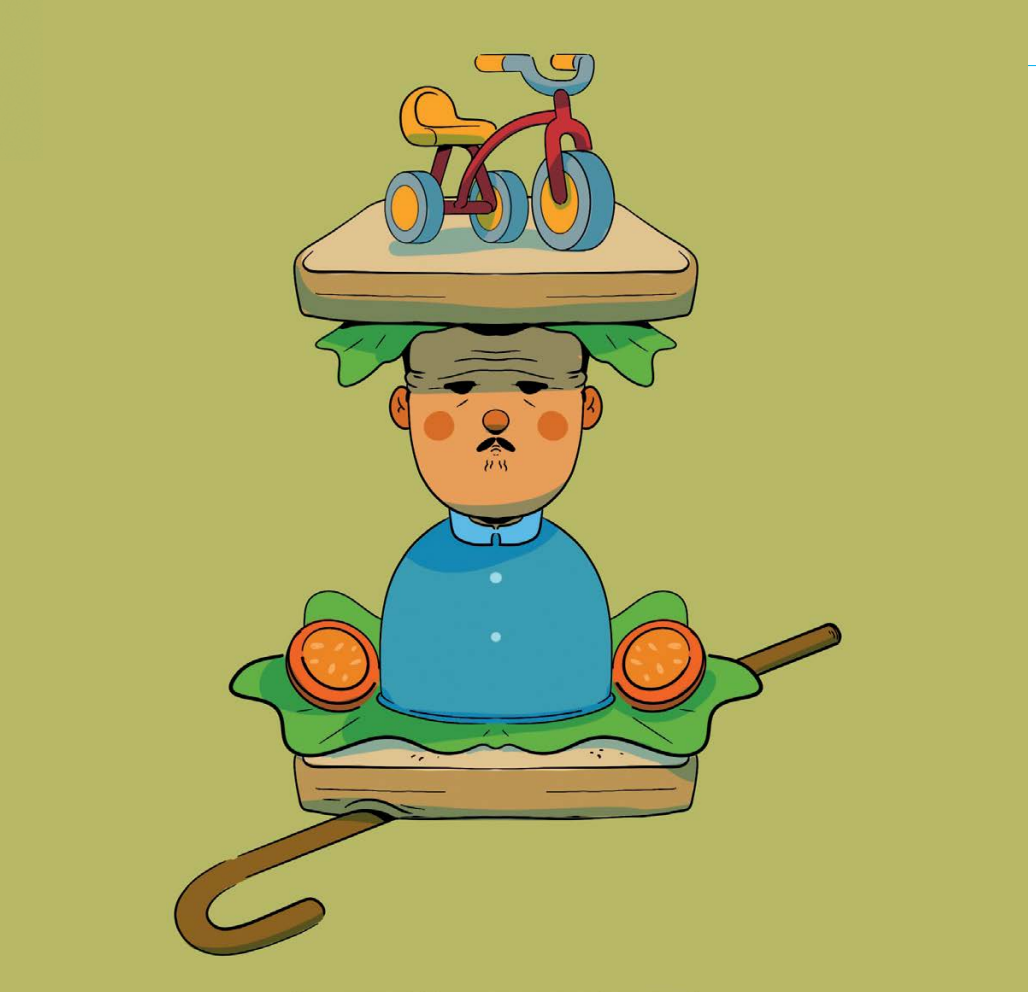


porting parents should be the focus (see *Whose Needs Come First?*). In the Arora household, money has not been so much of an issue, but with exchange rates fluctuating, college fees for the daughter who is studying abroad have made them realise how the best of plans sometimes come undone.

"We had been saving up for our children's education and felt the savings would work out. But, with the fall of the rupee, everything is expensive. Add to it, our daughter couldn't secure a campus accommodation, which upset the finances further," describes Rashi. To add to their financial woes, her father-in-law suffered a stroke. Her husband Uday's business was doing well, but like any other business, it had its share of cashflow issues. "We are fine, but there are times when receivable payments get delayed and it is a matter of concern," she says. The hospitalisation cost and the need for a full-time help to look after her father-in-law add to their monthly expenses.

BRINGING ORDER

Maintaining two or more households may seem daunting, but proper financial planning today will go a long way to ease your financial burden over the long term. Being part of the Sandwich Generation can create unique challenges in shaping your financial plan. You may be trying to balance the financial goals and needs of your spouse and children against the financial needs of your parents and in-laws when it comes to things like managing everyday expenses and the usual financial goals. If you're caught in the financial squeeze, it's important to rethink your approach to short- and long-term planning when it comes to your money.

WHEN YOU HAVE KIDS, YOUR FINANCES MAY BE STRESSED EVEN BEFORE YOU CONSIDER HELPING OUT AGING PARENTS

The Shastri household was always financially comfortable. They had the necessary comforts, but they never went overboard and limited their lifestyle expenses well within their means. Seshadri's father taught mathematics in the university, and made sure his son and elder daughter were well-educated. When Seshadri was in school, the house had a single floor, his grandfather had a shop, and his two aunts lived nearby. Family gatherings over weekends and festivals were a given. They all chipped in to do household chores and life was simple.

"I think the tragic and sudden death of my grandfather in a road accident changed things. Suddenly, it came to my father to manage the household expenses," he narrates. His father didn't know the poor financial condition of the shop or that his father had taken a loan, a small one at the time of his younger sister's marriage. The senior Shastri single-mindedly worked to get debt-free at the earliest and even sold the shop his father ran to square off the debt taken to run it. "I remember my grandmother not at all being pleased at the shop being sold and nor were my aunts," he adds.

Two important lessons emerged from his grandfather's demise—have life insurance to address financial commitments and never borrow beyond your repaying ability. These fundamental financial principles hold true for everyone. The foundation of any sound financial plan rests on risk and sound debt management. In the case of multi-generational families; health insurance is very important, as healthcare costs are on the rise and finding appropriate medical insurance in old age is difficult as well as expensive. "Even when you do get it, chances